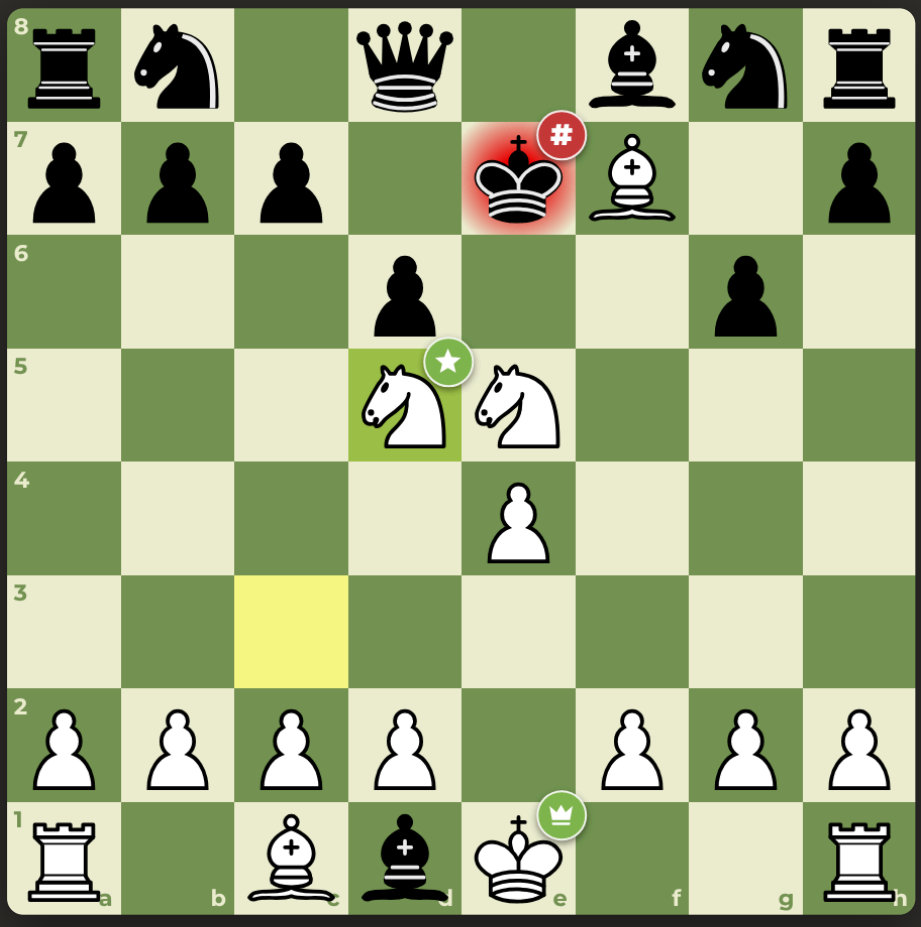
@CHECKSMATEDAILY

10 Chess Traps Every Beginner Must Know

Win fast. Never fall for them yourself.
For players rated 0–1500.



Every move checked by Stockfish

How to use this guide

1. **Set up each trap on a real board** and play it through once with both colours.
2. **Cover the arrow** on the left diagram and try to find the key move yourself.
3. **Read "How to stop it"**: your opponents know some of these too.
4. **Watch the animated version** on Instagram: @checksmatedaily.

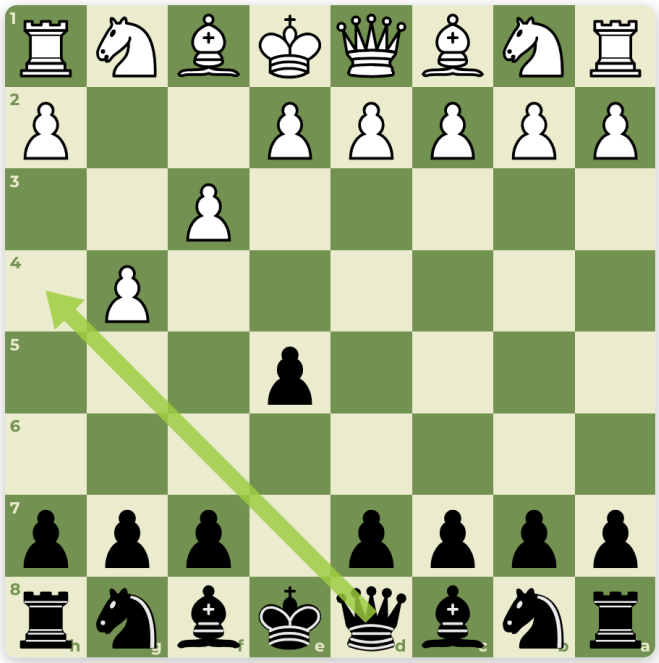
1	Fool's Mate	0–300 ELO
2	Scholar's Mate	0–300 ELO
3	Back Rank Mate	0–300 ELO
4	Légal's Mate	300–600 ELO
5	Blackburne Shilling Trap	300–600 ELO
6	Stafford Gambit Trap	300–600 ELO
7	Englund Gambit Trap	600–900 ELO
8	Elephant Trap	600–900 ELO
9	Kieninger Trap	600–900 ELO
10	Fishing Pole Trap	900–1500 ELO

TRAP 1 0–300 ELO

You play Black

Fool's Mate

The **fastest** checkmate in chess. Only **2 moves**. Seriously.



Find the mate: Qh4#



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. f3** White pushes the f-pawn. The king gets **weaker**.
2. **1... e5** We open a path for our **queen**.
3. **2. g4** Another pawn push. **Huge mistake!**
4. **2... Qh4#** Queen to h4. The king is **trapped**. **Checkmate!**

Remember

- Don't push your **f and g pawns** early.
- They are your king's **bodyguards**.
- Open line to the king = **danger**.

🛡 How to stop it

- Keep your **f and g pawns** home early.
- Start with **e4 or d4**, then knights.
- Open line to your king? **Close it**.

TRAP 2 0–300 ELO

You play White

Scholar's Mate

Checkmate in **4 moves**. Beginners fall for this **all the time**.



Find the mate: Qxf7#



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. e4** Pawn to e4. This opens the door for our **queen** and **bishop**.
2. **1... e5** Black copies us. Totally normal.
3. **2. Bc4** Bishop out. It's **aiming at f7**.
4. Look at f7. Only the **king** protects it. That's the **weak spot**!
5. **2... Nc6** Black brings out a knight. Looks fine...
6. **3. Qh5** Queen out! Now **two pieces** attack f7.
7. **3... Nf6** Black attacks our queen... but **forgets about f7**!
8. **4. Qxf7#** Queen takes f7. The bishop protects her. **Checkmate!**

Remember

- Queen + bishop attack **f7**.
- If they forget to defend it: **game over**.
- Playing Black? Stop it with **...g6** or **...Qe7**.

🛡 How to stop it

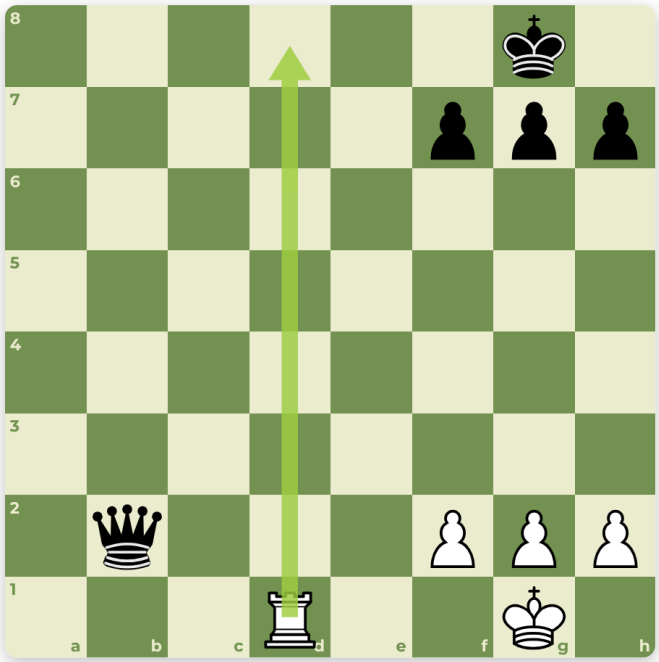
- Queen on h5? Play **...g6**.
- Queen on f3? Block with **...Nf6**.
- Early queen = **easy target**.

TRAP 3 0–300 ELO

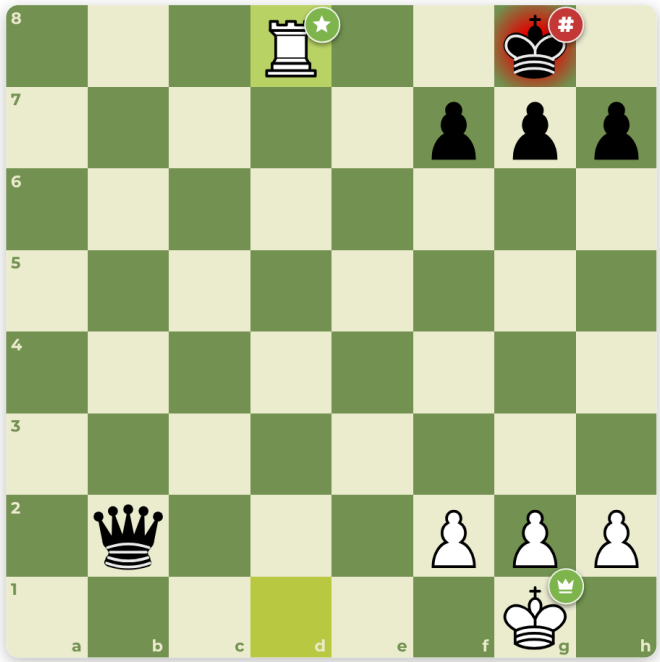
You play White

Back Rank Mate

They have a **queen**. We have a rook. We still win in **1 move**.



Find the mate: Rd8#



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. Black has a **queen**. Black is winning... right?
2. Look at their king. It's stuck **behind its own pawns**. No exit!
3. **1... Qxb2** Black gets greedy and grabs a pawn.
4. **2. Rd8#** Rook to the back row. The king **can't escape**. **Checkmate!**

Remember

- King with **no exit** squares? Look at the back row.
- One rook can **end the game**.
- Protect yourself: give your king **one free square** (like h6).

🛡 How to stop it

- King stuck on the back row = **danger**.
- Make **one escape square** (h6 or g6).
- Then grab material **safely**.

TRAP 4 300–600 ELO

You play White

Légal's Mate

Give away your **queen**... and **checkmate** 2 moves later.



Key move: Nxe5 !!



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. e4 e5 2. Nf3** Normal start. Our knight **attacks e5**.
2. **2... d6** Black protects it with a pawn.
3. **3. Bc4** Bishop out. Aiming at f7, the **weak spot**.
4. **3... Bg4** Black pins our knight. 'If it moves, I **take your queen**!'
5. **4. Nc3 g6** We bring out a piece. Black plays a **slow move**. Now the trap is ready.
6. **5. Nxe5** Knight takes e5! We **leave our queen** to die!
7. **5... Bxd1** Black grabs the queen. **Big mistake.**
8. **6. Bxf7+** Bishop takes f7. **Check!**
9. **6... Ke7** The king has only **one square** to go.
10. **7. Nd5#** Knight to d5. **Checkmate!** Three small pieces beat a queen.

Remember

- A pin to the **queen** is not a real pin.
- Sometimes giving the queen **wins the game**.
- Free queen? First check for **checkmate**.

🛡 How to stop it

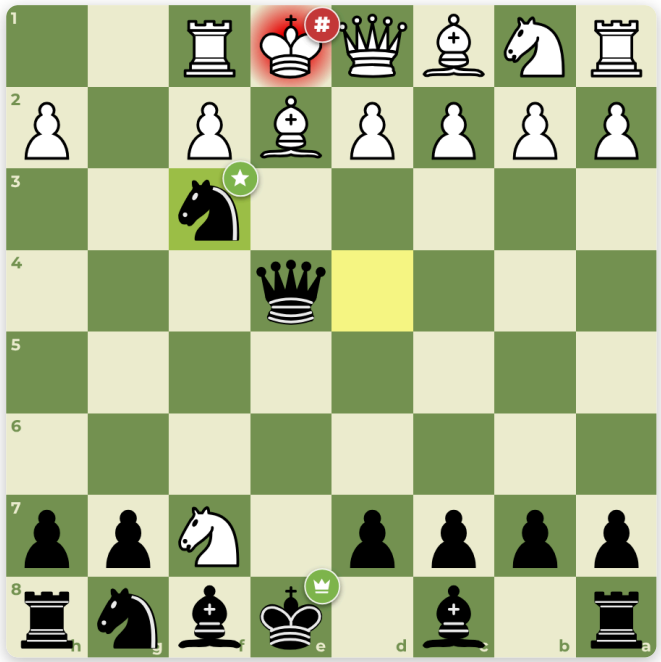
- Pinned their knight? Play **...Nf6** next.
- Guard **d5** and the trap dies.
- Never play **...g6** there.

Blackburne Shilling Trap

This move looks like a **blunder**... but it ends in **checkmate**.



Find the mate: Nf3#



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bc4 Nd4** Knight to d4. Now e5 looks **free**...
2. **4. Nxe5** White takes it. **Here we go.**
3. **4... Qg5** Queen to g5! She hits the knight **and** g2.
4. **5. Nxf7 Qxg2** White grabs f7. We grab g2!
5. **6. Rf1 Qxe4+** The rook runs. Queen takes e4. **Check!**
6. **7. Be2 Nf3#** Knight to f3. The bishop is **pinned**. **Checkmate!**

Remember

- If they grab e5, play **...Qg5!**
- Ignore the knight. **Attack g2**.
- ...Nd4 is risky. It works when they **grab e5**.

🛡 How to stop it

- Knight on d4? **Take it**, not e5.
- Free pawns can be **poison**.
- Castle early, stay **safe**.

TRAP 6 300–600 ELO

You play Black

Stafford Gambit Trap

White takes our **queen**... and gets **checkmated** right away.



Key move: Nxe4 !!



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nf6 3. Nxe5 Nc6** We give a pawn. The **Stafford Gambit**.
2. **4. Nxc6 dxc6 5. d3 Bc5** Our bishop aims at **f2**.
3. **6. Bg5** White pins our knight to the queen.
4. **6... Nxe4** We move it anyway! **Take my queen!**
5. **7. Bxd8 Bxf2+** White takes it. Bishop takes f2. **Check!**
6. **8. Ke2 Bg4#** Bishop to g4. **Checkmate!**

Remember

- Bishop on c5 = **pressure on f2**.
- Pinned to the queen? You can **still move**.
- Before taking a queen, check for **checks**.

🛡 How to stop it

- Against the Stafford: **Be2**, not Bg5.
- Guard **f2** and g4.
- Then castle and **stay calm**.

TRAP 7 600–900 ELO

You play Black

Englund Gambit Trap

White takes a **free pawn**. 6 moves later: **checkmate**.



Find the mate: Qc1#



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. d4 e5** We throw a pawn at them. The **Englund Gambit**.
2. **2. dxe5 Nc6 3. Nf3** White takes and protects it.
3. **3... Qe7** Queen to e7. We attack e5 **again**.
4. **4. Bf4** White protects it one more time.
5. **4... Qb4+** Queen to b4. **Check!** And she's eyeing **b2**.
6. **5. Bd2 Qxb2** We take b2. Now we attack the **rook** in the corner.
7. **6. Bc3** White attacks our queen. **This is the mistake.**
8. **6... Bb4** Bishop to b4! Their bishop is now **pinned**.
9. **7. Qd2** White protects with the queen.
10. **7... Bxc3** We take the bishop. Our queen **doesn't care**.
11. **8. Qxc3** White takes back... **and walks into it**.
12. **8... Qc1#** Queen to c1. **Checkmate!**

Remember

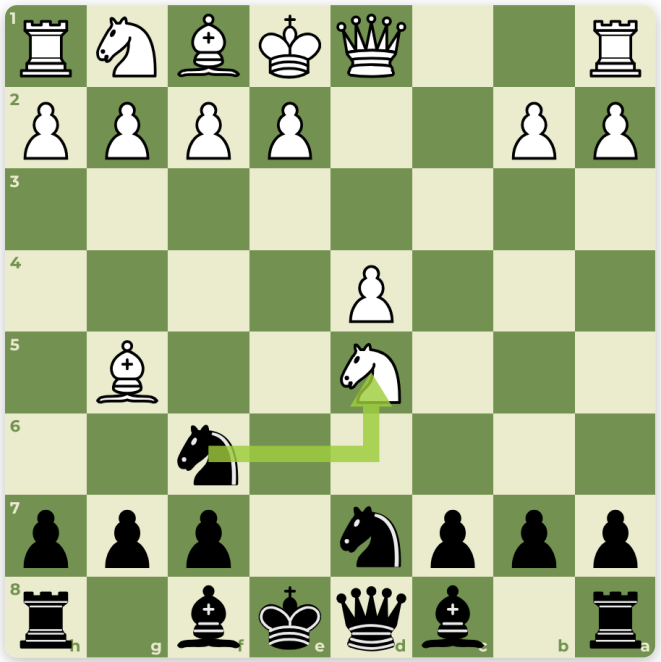
- Gambit = give a pawn to **attack fast**.
- Pin pieces to the king with your **bishop**.
- Every move, ask: what are their **checks**?

🛡 How to stop it

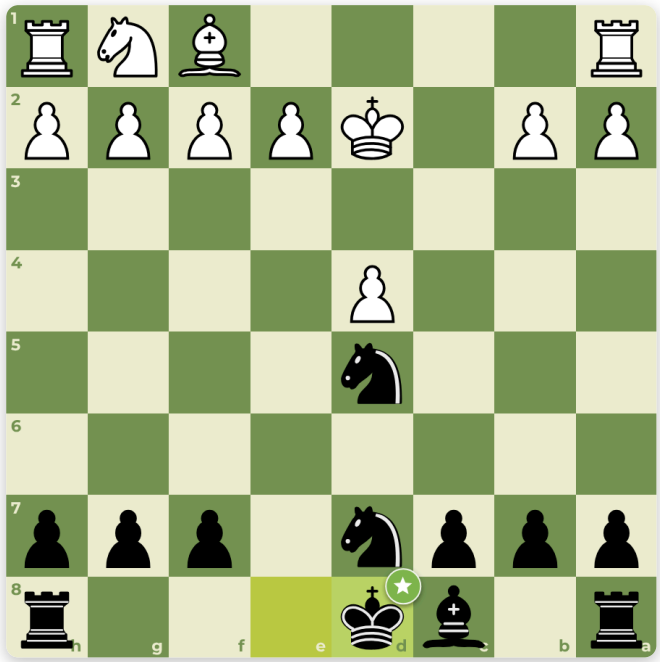
- Queen on b2? Play **Nc3**, then Rb1.
- Never **Bc3** there: it gets pinned.
- Chase the **greedy queen**!

Elephant Trap

White thinks they **won a pawn**. Really, they just **lost a piece**.



Key move: Nxd5 !!



Final position: Kxd8

How it works

1. **1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Nbd7** White pins our knight. We **quietly** set the trap.
2. **5. cxd5 exd5 6. Nxd5** White grabs d5. 'Your knight is pinned!'
3. **6... Nxd5** Surprise! We take anyway and **give our queen**.
4. **7. Bxd8 Bb4+** White takes it. Bishop **check**!
5. **8. Qd2 Bxd2+ 9. Kxd2** Only the queen can block. We **take it**.
6. **9... Kxd8** Then the bishop. We're **a whole piece up**!

Remember

- A pinned knight can **still move**.
- Lose your queen, take **theirs** + a piece.
- Free pawn? Count the **checks** first.

🛡 How to stop it

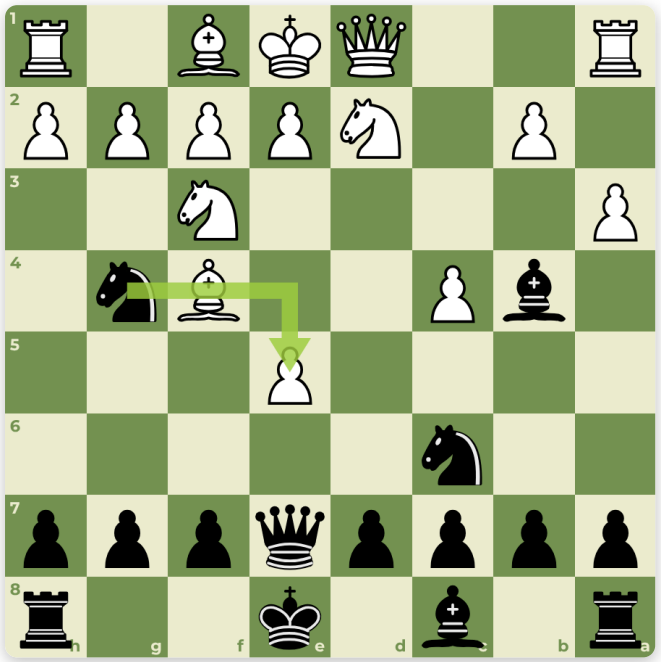
- Pinned to the queen = **not** fully pinned.
- Free pawn? Check what **they** get.
- Solid moves win **at your level**.

TRAP 9 600–900 ELO

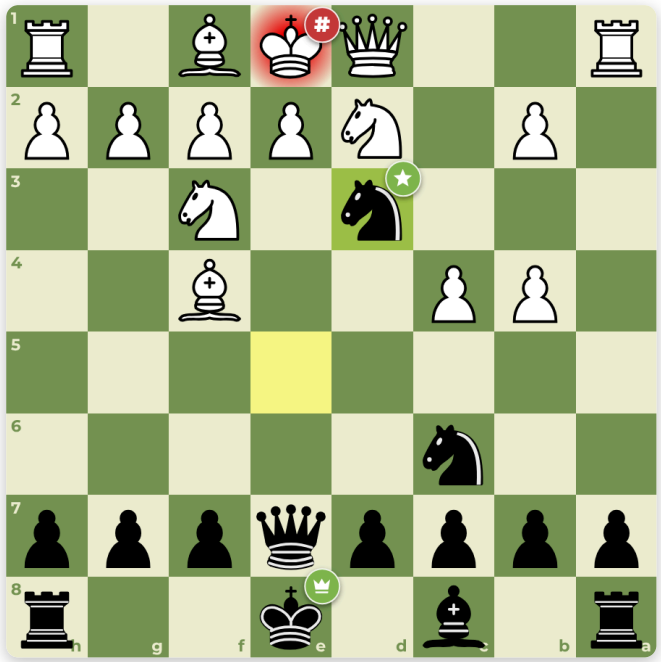
You play Black

Kieninger Trap

White takes our **bishop**. Next move: **checkmate**.



Key move: Ngxe5 !



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. d4 Nf6 2. c4 e5 3. dxe5 Ng4** We give a pawn. The **Budapest Gambit**.
2. **4. Nf3 Nc6 5. Bf4 Bb4+ 6. Nbd2 Qe7** Now **three** pieces hit e5.
3. **7. a3** White attacks our bishop.
4. **7... Ngxe5** We ignore it and take e5! **Leave the bishop.**
5. **8. axb4** White takes the free bishop...
6. The e2 pawn is **pinned**. The king is **boxed in**.
7. **8... Nd3#** Knight to d3. **Smothered checkmate!**

Remember

- Pin the **e2 pawn** with your queen.
- King boxed in by its own pieces = **knight mate**.
- Free bishop? Check for **mate** first.

🛡 How to stop it

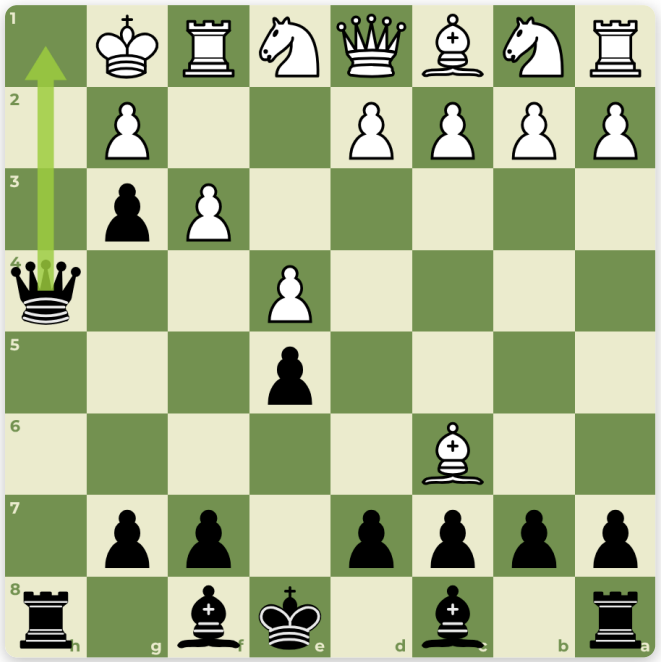
- Budapest Gambit? Play **e3** early.
- Don't let your king get **boxed in**.
- **a3** there is a trap!

TRAP 10 900–1500 ELO

You play Black

Fishing Pole Trap

Throw your knight as **bait**... and catch a **checkmate**.



Find the mate: Qh1#



Final position: checkmate

How it works

1. **1. e4 e5 2. Nf3 Nc6 3. Bb5 Nf6 4. O-O Ng4** Knight to g4. It's our **fishing pole**!
2. **5. h3 h5** White kicks it. We **leave it there**.
3. **6. hxg4 hxg4** White bites! Now the h-file is **open**.
4. **7. Ne1 Qh4** Queen to h4. **Threat:** mate on h1!
5. **8. f3 g3** Pawn to g3. Now **nothing** stops mate.
6. **9. Bxc6 Qh1#** Queen to h1. **Checkmate!**

Remember

- Taking the bait **opens the h-file**.
- Rook + queen on an open file = **mate**.
- Risky trap: it only works if they **take the bait**.

🛡 How to stop it

- Free knight next to your king? **Bait**.
- Don't open the **h-file**.
- Play the **center** instead.

Want more traps?

A bigger guide with **40+ traps** and **how to stop every one of them** is coming soon.

Follow **@checksmatedaily** for a new chess trap every day and "Brilliant or Blunder?" puzzles.

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